

Tactical Protocol: Your Opponent's Turn

Jeff Cunningham
Magic Academy
Saturday, April 14, 2007



Hello, and welcome to Magic Academy! This week we're again going to look at tactical aspects of timing: when to play spells and effects, and why. [Last week](#) we looked at the options on your own turn; this week, we'll look at the intricacies of timing during your opponent's turn.

Remember, on your opponent's turn they have priority. In short, that means that they get a chance to do things first (although you can respond as soon as they do). This is often an advantage. They must make decisions without knowing whether you intend to make a play during that phase. If you opt not to after they've passed, the step ends.

Your Opponent's Turn

When and why to initiate spells

1. Beginning Phase

Untap step: All of your opponent's tapped permanents untap. Nothing can be played during this step.

Upkeep step: The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's upkeep step is that it is after they untap, but before they draw. It is also your first chance to make a play on your opponent's turn.

Generally, if your opponent is tapped out on your own turn and it's important that you resolve a spell, you should play it on your own turn. If they already have relevant permanents (generally lands) untapped, however, you might as well wait until their upkeep. That way if they respond then at least they'll have to tap permanents they could have used during their turn.

- **Opponent's-turn-related:** It is the earliest phase in your opponent's turn. If you have a spell that specifically needs to be played during your opponent's turn to be useful, this is often the time to do it.

Example: During my upkeep, you play **Orim's Chant**.

- **Mana-deprivation-related:** Similarly, if you have an effect that taps an opponent's mana sources, this is usually the time to use them. Yes, they can use the mana for spells during their beginning phase, but they won't be able to use it for the non-instants.

Example: During my upkeep, you activate **Icy Manipulator**, targeting my **Island**.

- **Upkeep-effect-related:** As with your own turn, sometimes it's important to navigate various upkeep effects.

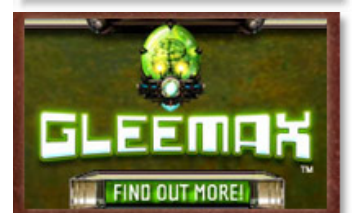
Example: I **Shock** you, to empty my hand for **Imaginary Pet**. Before its ability resolves, you play **Boomerang** on my **Island**.



Draw step: The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's draw step is that it is after they've drawn, but before they're able to initiate non-instant spells. *

- **Hand-size-related:** If a card's utility depends on your opponent's number of cards in hand, this may be a good time to play it.

Example: During my draw step, you target me with **Sudden Impact**.



Example: I have no cards in hand, and then I draw for the turn. During my draw step, you target me with **Funeral Charm's** discard ability.

2. First Main Phase

The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's first main phase is that it is before combat. They'll be positioning themselves for a successful combat step. You'll often have opportunities to respond to spells during this phase.

3. Combat Phase

Beginning of Combat step: The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's beginning of combat step is that it is after they are able to play non-instants, but before they have declared their attackers.

- **Tap effects:** This is the time to tap potential attackers.

Sometimes this is done during the upkeep, or in response to card draw, in case your opponent draws a split second card (say, **Krosan Grip** for your **Icy Manipulator**), countermagic, or an untargetability effect, but in general it's best to wait until the last moment. This way, you have all the information on what they've done during their first main phase.

Example: During my beginning of combat step, you activate **Master Decoy** targeting their **Shivan Dragon**.

Example: I have **Grizzly Bears** in play. I play **Viashino Sandstalker**, which has haste, and move into my beginning of combat step. You activate **Master Decoy** targeting **Viashino Sandstalker**.

Declare Attackers step: Your opponent starts their declare attackers step by deciding which creatures are going to attack and tapping them. Then, each player gets a chance to play spells and abilities. The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's declare attackers step is that it is after your opponent has committed to their attacks, but before you have committed to your blocks. This is a time to gather information.

- **Information-related:** You can force your opponent to use a spell or ability before they know how you're going to block, or check to make sure a spell or ability of your own resolves the way you want it to before making a block.

Example: I'm at 2 life with a **Grizzly Bears** in play. You attack me with **Raging Goblin** and **Craw Wurm**. I **Dark Banishing** the **Craw Wurm** before blockers. If you have a counterspell to save the Wurm, I will be forced to block it, but at least I won't be dead. If you don't, then I get to safely block and kill the **Raging Goblin**.

Example: You attack me with two **Hill Giants**, and you have an **Angelic Page** untapped. I have a **Craw Wurm**. I **Shock** your **Angelic Page** now. Whichever **Hill Giant** you pump, I can leave unblocked and take 4 damage. Whichever you don't, I can kill with **Craw Wurm**.



Declare Blockers step: You start this step by declaring which of your creatures will block which attacking creatures. Then, each player has the chance to play spells or abilities. After you have declared blockers, the most

significant tactical aspect of your opponent's declare blockers step is that it is the last step before combat damage is assigned, and your opponent has priority.

- **Power- or toughness-related:** As with your own turn, this is the last chance to pump up (or shrink) creatures before they would deal damage. Again, this includes formal pump (**Giant Growth**), removal (**Dark Banishing**), and shrinking effects (Shrink).

There are a couple differences from your own turn, though. You must now consider damage that would be done to yourself.

Example: I attack you with two **Serpent Warriors**. You block one with a **Craw Wurm**, and kill the other with **Lightning Blast** before damage goes on the stack so that you won't take 3 damage.

- **Baiting:** Another consideration is the fact that your opponent now has priority. This means that their last chance to pump their creature before combat damage comes before your last chance to kill it. So, if you're planning on killing an attacking creature anyway, and you don't think your opponent has a way to counter it, then you should wait until the last moment in order to potentially draw out a (useless) trick.

Example: You have a **Dark Banishing**. I attack you with **Craw Wurm**. You block with **Shivan Dragon**. I play **Giant Growth**. You play **Dark Banishing**.

OR

You have a **Dark Banishing**. I attack you with **Craw Wurm**. You block with **Shivan Dragon**. I pass priority. You play **Dark Banishing**.

Combat Damage step: At the beginning of the combat damage step, each player chooses how creatures he or she controls will deal damage. If any of the creatures has first strike, there are two separate combat damage steps. The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's combat damage step is mostly the same as your own: it is after damage has been assigned but is the last step before it resolves.

- **Prevention-related:** Again, this can include formal damage prevention (**Mending Hands**), pump (**Fortify's** +0/+2 option), and bounce (**Boomerang**). At this point, pump no longer includes the possibility of the death of an attacker. Bounce on an opposing creature will not prevent your creature from dying, but bounce on your own creature will nevertheless result in your opponent's creature's death.

Additionally, you now have motivation to play cards such as **Holy Day** to prevent damage to *yourself*.



- **Sacrifice effects:** This is a situation that I overlooked last week that comes up all the time. Once damage is on the stack—pending, whether or not the creatures that were responsible for this damage are around when it resolves—is the key time to sacrifice a creature for a particular ability, if the creature is going to die anyway.

Example: You block my **Lightning Elemental** with **Bottle Gnomes**. Once combat damage is on the stack (during the combat damage step), you sacrifice **Bottle Gnomes** to gain 3 life. The step ends and my **Lightning Elemental** dies.

Another detail to remember is that the sacrificed creature is never actually dealt damage. This is sometimes relevant in affecting combat damage-related effects and abilities.

Example: I'm attacking with a **Hill Giant** equipped with **Loxodon Warhammer**. You block with **Nantuko Husk**. I assign 2 damage to the Husk and 4 trample damage to you. With combat damage on the stack, you sacrifice the Husk to its own ability. Because of this, once damage resolves, I only gain 4 when I would have gained 6.

End of Combat step: The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's end of combat step is that it takes place after damage has resolved, but while combat is still technically taking place. This is an irregularly used step.

- **Post-damage-related:** Sometimes it is important to wait until combat damage has resolved to use a combat-specific effect (like **Heavy Ballista's**). It denies your opponent the chance to potentially use an effect to affect combat after they see what you do.

Example: After normal damage resolves, I'll use **Crossbow Infantry** to finish off your **Sanctum Guardian**. If I had done this while damage was yet to resolve, you could have used it to prevent damage to another one of your blockers. (If you did use it to prevent damage to another of your blockers anyway, then at least I would keep an untapped Infantry.)

- **Affect mana sources:** If combat ends and you find yourself with additional resources (or reason) to inhibit your opponent's mana sources for their second main phase (and last opportunity to play non-instants before their next turn), then this is the last chance to do it.

Example: After the way that attack went, my only chance to win is to play **Blaze** for 6 this turn. I have 6 land and a **Fellwar Stone** in play. You **Shatter** my **Fellwar Stone** during my end of combat step.



4. Second Main Phase

The most significant tactical aspect of your opponent's second main phase is that it is their default phase for playing sorcery-speed spells. You will often be responding a lot in this phase. Other than that, it is rare to have reason to initiate spells or abilities during this phase.

5. End Phase

End of Turn step: The most significant tactical aspects of your opponent's end of turn step are that their chance to play non-instants has expired and that it is your last phase before you untap. This makes it a safe and natural place to want to play instants and abilities, and indeed it is the default place to play instants and abilities.

- **Resolve unused abilities:** This is the time to use any renewable (i.e., tap-related) ability you had been waiting on.

Example: At the end of my turn, you ping me with **Prodigal Pyromancer**.

Of course, this also applies to tapping land.

Example: At the end of my turn, since I didn't play anything you wanted to counter, you use your land to play **Fact or Fiction**.

- **Pick a fight:** This is a good time to "pick a fight"; engage your opponent in a battle of instants and abilities (usually ones they have a heavy incentive to deal with). Even if it goes badly for you, you will get to untap all of your permanents and start another "fight" on your own turn, while your opponent is still weary.

Example: At the end of my turn, you play **Fact or Fiction**. I **Cancel** it. You **Mana Leak** my **Cancel**. I tap out to **Mana Leak** your **Mana Leak**. You untap on your next turn and tap all of your mana to play **Shivan Dragon**.

Example: At the end of my turn, you use **Prodigal Pyromancer** to ping my **Royal Assassin**. I tap **Samite Healer** to prevent the damage. On your turn, you use the Pyromancer again. This time I can't prevent the damage, and my Assassin dies.

Cleanup step: This is when damage is removed from creatures and "until end of turn" effects end. Nothing can be played during this step.

That's it for this week. Join me next time when we approach tactics on a deeper level...

Jeff



* There is another type of play that might come up here as well, when top-of-library effects are used against mana-sources. I am reminded of a particularly delightful play made against Bill Stead at GP: New Orleans a few years ago. I was playing U/G Madness against his Green

creature-combo deck. In his draw step, I targeted a **Llanowar Elves** with a **Submerge**. This way, he would not draw the Elves this turn, only next turn when it would be much less useful, and would also not be able to derive mana from it for the purpose of playing non-instants. This is extremely marginal.

*A highly respected Pro Tour competitor and popular Internet writer, Jeff Cunningham has been playing **Magic** for more than 10 years. In 2006, Jeff was voted as a "Fan Favorite" choice into the Magic Invitational, where he finished 2nd. Other **Magic** accomplishments include Top 8 at Pro Tour–San Diego 2002, and three Grand Prix Top 8s including a win in Philadelphia.*

Jeff currently attends the University of British Columbia in Vancouver, Canada.



[Discuss](#) on the message boards



[Jeff Cunningham](#) archive

[About Us](#) | [Jobs](#) | [New to the Game?](#) | [Inside Wizards](#) | [Find a Store](#) | [Press](#) | [Help](#) | [Sitemap](#)

© 1995-2008 Wizards of the Coast, Inc., a subsidiary of Hasbro, Inc. All Rights Reserved.
[Terms of Use](#) - [Privacy Statement](#)

